

Trade Negotiation Briefing Paper: Japan

May 8, 2024

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Executive Summary:

Section I. Improving market access: Japanese fishing exports in Chinese markets

- Japan requests that the Chinese government reverse its restriction on imports of seafood from Japanese fisheries
- Contamination levels of Japanese seafood following the release of Fukushima wastewater are well within the safe range, and fisheries have conformed to existing fishing agreements
- China's restrictions on fisheries potentially breach international conduct regarding national treatment and non-charge restrictions

Section II. Change in WTO rule: Qualifying emergencies of environmental nature when invoking trade exceptions

- Existing environmental regulation uses scientific precedent to qualify an environmental hazard and harmonize with international standards, but legal infrastructure for identifying scenarios producing environmental hazards and of what severity is lacking
- Japan requests the adoption of a generalized procedure to qualify environmental emergencies and accordingly streamline governmental response, which is described

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Section I. Improving market access: Japanese fishing exports in Chinese markets

Japan requests that the Chinese government reverse its restriction on imports of seafood from Japanese fisheries. In FY2022 mainland China was the largest importer of Japanese seafood, totalling a record ¥87.1 billion. China induced restrictions on Japanese fisheries as a response to Japan discharging wastewater from the damaged Fukushima Daiichi nuclear power station (FDNPS) into the Pacific Ocean, beginning 2 November 2023, to protect citizens' health (Nikkei Asia; White). Consequently Japanese seafood exports to China have fallen by as much as 91 percent (Hironori; Japan Times).

The position of Chinese government spokespeople is that Japanese fishing restrictions were imposed to protect citizens' lives and health from "the risk of radioactive contamination of food" fishes from the Pacific Ocean (Nakagawa; Nikkei Asia). The contaminant most saliently in question is tritium, a radioactive isotope of hydrogen, which was emitted into wastewater used to cool FDNPS following its partial meltdown. To this end, the International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA) assigned a task force representing eleven countries to analyze treated wastewater samples taken from FDNPS. Analyses were conducted by:

- Tokyo Electric Power Company (TEPCO)
- IAEA Marine Environment Laboratories, Radiometrics Laboratory (RML), Monaco;
- Terrestrial Environmental Radiochemistry Laboratory (TERC), Seibersdorf, Austria;
- Isotope Hydrology Laboratory (IHL), Vienna, Austria.

and a interlaboratory comparison corroborated by:

- Spiez Laboratory (LS – Labor Spiez), Switzerland
- Institut de Radioprotection et de Sûreté Nucléaire (IRSN), France
- Los Alamos National Laboratory (LANL), United States of America
- Korea Institute of Nuclear Safety (KINS), Republic of Korea

in short, an impartial and international committee (IAEA, 2023a, 107). The IAEA report found that TEPCO had correctly concluded Fukushima wastewater was well within the safe level of

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tritium concentration, and Japan could proceed with decontamination. The report additionally found that no laboratory “detected any additional radionuclides at significant levels.” (IAEA, 2023a, 108) IAEA Director General Rafael Mariano Grossi noted in a foreword that “the controlled, gradual discharges of the treated water to the sea, as currently planned and assessed by TEPCO, would have a negligible radiological impact on people and the environment” (IAEA, 2023ab).

The Group of Seven and the United States government have issued statements reaffirming the safety of releasing Fukushima wastewater (White). Tritium activity concentration at the boundary of the interested region around FDNPS will be between 0.0001 and 0.0003 becquerels per liter; the background activity concentration in the North Pacific Ocean between latitudes 30 and 45 N is 0.04 becquerels per liter, suggesting tritium concentration of the sea around FDNPS from discharged wastewater will still be a fraction of environmental conditions. (IAEA, 2023a, 81) The World Health Organization allows tritium concentration of up to 10000 becquerels per liter in drinking water (TEPCO 5, 9).

The Chinese government’s restriction on imports from Japanese fisheries, said to protect citizen health, invokes Article XX(b) of the General Agreement on Tariffs and Trade (GATT), which allows exceptions to international trade conduct when “necessary to protect human, animal or plant life or health” (WTO, e(iii), 562-564). This exception has been proceduralized by the Agreement on the Application of Sanitary and Phytosanitary (SPS) Measures. By SPS Article 2(2) Chinese restrictions can extend to the degree necessary to protect health as dictated by “scientific principles” and maintained with “sufficient scientific evidence”. By Article 3(1) SPS measures must be predicated on “international standards, guidelines or recommendations”

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(WTO, g, 69-71; Nakagawa). The IAEA is the premiere international authority regarding nuclear contamination, and is recognized as such through integration with the United Nations (UN) system. Further, IAEA analyses are by review impartial (the IAEA report observed that cooperation with interested parties only extended to procuring data) and set by international scientific standards (97). As the IAEA finds that FDNPS decontamination is safe and negligibly risks health, the Code of Conduct for Responsible Fisheries Article 6.14 sees that Japanese fisheries have followed international standards appropriately (Code of Conduct, 7). Then Chinese restrictions are unnecessary and so cannot be excepted by GATT Article XX(b) or similarly inspired law.

Japan has set an annual tritium discharge limit at 22 terabecquerels per year (IAEA, 2023a, 22-43). While operating within this limit, the Chinese government has imposed restrictions on seafood farmed in seas with discharged wastewater. In contrast the tritium in wastewater at fifteen of nineteen sites monitored in China surpassed this limit, with the Qinshan Nuclear Power Plant discharging 202 terabecquerels in 2022. Consequently nearby Chinese fisheries in these areas experience higher levels of tritium contamination than Japanese fisheries proximate to FDNPS (China Nuclear Energy Association 23-236). Yet while Japanese fishery exports have been restricted due to risk of tritium radiation, no Chinese fisheries have experienced equivalent restriction.

Japan also notes Chinese restrictions have extended to seafood products sourced outside of the Pacific Ocean, though restrictions are said to be motivated by fear of radioactive pollution exclusively released to the Pacific Ocean. For instance, China following the discharge of FDNPS wastewater expired all remaining licenses to Japanese koi farms, mandating a 7-10 day

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quarantine period for all koi imports from Japan, which has halted Japanese export of koi to China (Yamaguchi). Prior to expiry, China accommodated for a fifth (approx. ¥1.2 billion) of Japanese koi exports (Chin). Koi are a freshwater fish and so cannot be contaminated with tritium released into the Pacific Ocean. There is no equivalent quarantine period experienced by domestic fish farming despite being exposed to equal or worse contamination and risk of disease.

In the absence of a valid exception (as the exception claimed by the Chinese government is environmental in nature and has been refuted, Japan now considers existing agreements without stipulation), Japan asserts that Chinese restrictions on seafood imports from Japan violate agreements including GATT Article III and GATT Article XI. By GATT Article III(2), Japanese seafood exports cannot be applied “to internal taxes or other internal charges of any kind in excess of those applied, directly or indirectly, to like domestic products”. As instantiated above, Japan finds restrictions on its seafood exports to be in excess of those applied to like Chinese products.

By GATT Article XI(1) no non-charge restrictions can be instituted by China on seafood imports from Japan without exception, which China has raised. The 1997 Fisheries Agreement qualifies Japanese fishing around FDNPS as either in Japanese territory or joint provisional waters zones (PMZs) with nearby countries, validating the invocation of Article XI(1) when evaluating Chinese restrictions (Rosenberg 2-3).

In what scenarios Article XI can be invoked in arbitration has been clarified by many prior disputes. Precedent from *Japan — Measures Affecting Agricultural Products* ruling finds that Article XI(2)(c) exceptions for non-charge restrictions extend only to the degree of restrictions of imports, rather than prohibitions; as China initiated a complete suspension of

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various Japanese seafood, its restriction cannot be excepted and is in violation of Article XI

(Geddie and Toyoda; WTO, f, 27-45). Precedent from *United States — Restrictions on Imports of Tuna* ruling means China cannot embargo Japanese seafood to enforce domestic policy in Japan e.g. to meet a particular level of tritium discharged; in negotiations over their ban, Chinese spokespeople have claimed Japan treats the ocean as its “private sewer” and encouraged Japan to “handle the issue properly” (White). In *Chile — Measures affecting the Transit and Importing of Swordfish*, the European Union and Chile wrote that fisheries in accordance with international environmental standard (which Japan has demonstrably operated under, as stated by the IAEA) should be granted access to the restricted ports in question, which China has not afforded (Lin; WTO, c, 4-6).

Japan recognizes that China places strong emphasis on citizen safety and environmental motives. These motives can still be achieved while acting in accordance with conduct mandated by international agreements. Japan hopes that China, as a WTO member, may continue to pursue its health and environmental safety objectives while reversing restrictions of seafood from Japanese fisheries in compliance with GATT and associated regulation.

Section II. Change in WTO rule: Qualifying emergencies of environmental nature when invoking trade exceptions

The interaction of the WTO trade system with countries’ environmental objectives is complex and boundaries of jurisdiction are often clouded. WTO doctrinal analysis is only competent when considering environmental impact on trade, which often manifests itself in the interplay of multilateral environmental agreements (MEAs) and WTO principle. Precedent from

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cases such as *United States — Restrictions on Imports of Tuna* ('tuna-dolphin') and *United States — Import Prohibition of Certain Shrimp and Shrimp Products* ('shrimp-turtle') find that provisions from MEAs are more suitable than having a country compel another to meet environmental standards (Brewster et al.; Kim; WTO, d). In managing more gradual environmental concerns, such as the stock of fish and carbon emissions, MEAs can be written and so there are existing provisions for the WTO system to act in parallel with. However, environmental emergencies often (by their nature) afford little warning to institutions and bring environmental challenges on a much shorter timeframe than that typically anticipated by policymakers when developing MEAs and other international law. Without an existing framework of environmental practice - which clarifies which exceptions to trade practice can be correctly invoked - WTO decision-making on environmental issues becomes incompetent and lacks collective scientific evidence, while countries are induced to coerce other agents to satisfy their environmental agenda for trade.

The Tōhoku earthquake and tsunami, and ensuing nuclear accident at FDNPS illustrates the issues that emerge in trade policy without a WTO framework for qualifying environmental emergencies. Following the nuclear accident, Japan has taken great measures to act in accordance with international watchdogs in monitoring nuclear contamination. Without a trade infrastructure to qualify the accident at FDNPS, while there was international presence in conducting disaster response, there was no commensurate collaboration in navigating trade (Kim). Particularly, this meant that countries were informed by MEAs when tailoring trade policy in response to the accident, but it was unclear whether trade policy inspired by existing agreements complied with WTO doctrine.

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Consequently countries such as the Republic of Korea and China (as prior instantiated) have instituted restrictions or prohibitions of imports of food products from Japan, for fear of nuclear contamination. The former dispute had to be resolved in *Korea — Import Bans, and Testing and Certification Requirements for Radionuclides*, while the latter is unresolved and has motivated Japan's prior complaint. In both cases, from a lack of clear guidance provided by existing trade infrastructure as to which exceptions can be correctly invoked, confusion has put unnecessary burden onto the dispute settlement mechanism (Kim; Obayashi). During this time, Japanese trade has suffered with the Republic of Korea, as pollack and mackerel exports to the Republic of Korea have fallen from 20,000 to 30,000 tons in 2010 to below 3,000 in 2018, and with China (as prior instantiated) (Tong-Hyung and Yamaguchi).

From this confusion and consequent lack of coordinated scientific understanding, Japan saw a 14.5 percent decrease in volume of merchandise trade in the two months following Tōhoku (March-May 2011). A quick rebound in production indicates that facilities or economic incentive for exchanging merchandise were not damaged; indeed, Japan's imports of merchandise from major markets actually grew in the months after. Rather, general lack of confidence in the stability and safety of Japanese merchandise production sank Japan's export to major markets by nearly 20 percent, which did not recover in the half-year following Tōhoku (DFAT 1-5). A better-coordinated emergency response would see an exchange of scientific information facilitate cooperative trade practice (Kim).

Alternately, Japan proposes a generalized procedure to qualify environmental emergencies and accordingly clarify and streamline appropriate governmental response (particularly, identifying which exceptions are credible). In this procedure, an affected country

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would declare an event or series of events to be an emergency, if substantiated by sufficient scientific evidence (WTO, g). To lawfully invoke trade exceptions, all countries affected by the emergency would then need to agree on the severity of said emergency, motivated by scientific principle and maintained by sufficient scientific evidence, including but not limited to

- 1) Whether an environmental emergency poses a hazard whose resolution or avoidance is “necessary to protect human, animal or plant life or health” (i.e. allowing for the invocation of GATT Article XX(b) in trade practice accordingly)
- 2) Whether an environmental emergency greatly alters the quantities of an agricultural or fisheries product (i.e. allowing for the invocation of Articles XI(c)(i-iii) in trade practice)
- 3) Whether an environmental emergency involves fissionable materials (i.e. allowing for the invocation of Article XXI(b)(i) in trade practice)
- 4) Whether an environmental emergency constitutes an emergency of international relations (i.e. allowing for the invocation of GATT Article XXI(b)(iii) in trade practice)

(WTO, e(i-iv)). This procedure would then allow for the necessitation of sufficient scientific evidence and principle in qualifying all WTO exceptions in an environmental context. This procedure is validated by:

- 1) The precedent of science in arbitration is one that WTO has recently encouraged, as evidenced by salient agreements such as SPS and the recently adopted Agreement on Fisheries Subsidies using standards such as “scientific principle” and “sufficient scientific evidence”, though the jurisdiction of these agreements (and so of scientific thought in WTO arbitration) has not been established to extend as far as Japan’s proposed environmental emergency procedure. Then this procedure is another step in integrating

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science into WTO doctrine, creating a more comprehensive system in evaluating environmentally impactful trade.

- 2) This procedure diminishes unnecessary baggage on the WTO dispute settlement system, an existing aim (WTO, g). The procedure encourages countries to collaborate on emergency response from a trade aspect from the onset by cooperatively establishing the degree of severity and corresponding evidence. Consequently countries are more likely to have an equivalent perspective on an environmental disaster and will act in parallel, minimizing the chance of dispute. The development of a body of scientific evidence also streamlines the process of dispute settlement, and should emphasize which perspective on trade practice and emergency severity is more correct. If a country (affected or otherwise) believes that the claimed degree of severity of an emergency or the motivated trade practice is unfair, it is then reasonable to submit a complaint.

In the context of the accident at FDNPS, the mutually accepted nature of accumulated scientific evidence would mean that foreign countries are dissuaded from improperly invoking exceptions in trade practice, as with China claiming nuclear contamination from discharged Fukushima wastewater constitutes a threat to health. Further, countries' proper understanding of the damage of the accident to Japanese facilities would clear misunderstandings and potentially lighten the dampening of Japanese exports to major markets. The immediate clarity as to the credible coverage of Article XXI(b)(i), as the emergency involves a nuclear reactor, would formalize the severity of the emergency and stimulate discussion on how to navigate trade.

Japan sees the coverage of Article XXI is fundamental to the proposed procedure.

Environmental emergencies are historically intertwined with national security interest (saliently,

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the Chernobyl disaster). Participation in the procedure is conditional on countries feeling their national security is preserved, which is a more foundational interest than responsible trade practice or alleviating WTO administrative baggage (WTO, e(iv), 600-608). Countries' engagement in the procedure is then conditional on the preservation of national security - by construction of the procedure, qualifying as an affected country is participatory, and so a country fearing for national security can exempt themselves accordingly. Further, the motivation of the procedure is in part to streamline countries' trade response to emergencies, which includes threats to national security. Then to encourage good faith in the proposed procedure and to assure countries that they are not compelled to engage in unnecessary effort to protect national security, Japan suggests a waiver programming Article XXI into the proposed procedure: that if a country feels an emergency is severe enough to invoke any security exceptions (i.e. any clauses of Article XXI), they need not declare an environmental emergency or agree with other countries on the severity on the emergency, and can independently act with exemption.

Japan finds that the proposed procedure for qualifying environmental emergencies would alleviate WTO administrative baggage and accelerate the development of comprehensive WTO doctrine integrated with the existing scientific and environmental landscape (and is in national interest). Considering the evidence given that the lack of infrastructure following environmental emergencies has depressed Japanese exports immediately following Tōhoku and in the lingering impacts of the accident at FDNPS, Japan hopes that the WTO adopts the proposed procedure.

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A handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to read 'Diego Luca Gonzalez Gauss', written in a cursive style.